The occasion of the conclusion of this agreement was a different world situation, and the causes which obliged us to profit by it are no longer existent...I announce the denunciation of the Anglo-Persian Agreement that it may not have a bad influence on our conduct of affairs...[20]

The wording of the declaration demonstrates Zia'eddin's efforts not to offend the British government by his actions. Indeed, he even suggested that Curzon send a note to the affect that the British government had concluded the agreement because it believed it to be in the best interests of the Persian people, but in no way insisted on its acceptance by the Persian government. Publication of such an announcement would 'at once add very greatly to our popularity and prestige here', as Norman put it.[21] Curzon responded that he had no time 'for a Gov. that simultaneously denounces and fawns'.[22]

The foreign secretary's reply to Norman not only illustrates the bitterness now apparent in his attitude towards Persia, but also hints at a cynicism in regards to that country's government. The rulers of Persia were in a difficult situation in this period: they did not want to alienate the British government, but needed to distance themselves from an agreement so derided by the Persian public that it had contributed to the downfall of the men who had aided its creation. As Zia'eddin tried to explain to Norman, 'if Great Britain wished to save her position here she must sacrifice shadow for substance, remain in the background and help Persia effectively but ostentatiously'.[23] For Curzon and others in the Foreign Office, however, such caution by the Persian government was taken as proof of its insincerity towards Britain. The attempts made by Zia'eddin in April of 1921 to enlist American advisors to help with some of Persia's administrative issues – including bringing back W.M. Shuster to head a Persian national bank – appeared to confirm such suspicions.[24] While Norman tried to explain that the Persian prime minister was simply hoping to create a strong and reformed Persia by seeking any help he could,[25] to Curzon such courting of Washington amounted to a betrayal of Britain.[26] The foreign secretary was